PRODUCT THINKING · WORKING SESSION

Feature Working Session: From Competitor Mechanics to BeReal Passport

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> *Independent concept created for a UI/UX Design & Product Management Externship. Not affiliated with or endorsed by BeReal.*

This page walks through how I went from competitor research to the features in BeReal Passport & Community Boards: what I looked at, what I kept, what I rejected, and why. It's structured as a working session, so the reasoning behind each decision is visible.

1. Frame the problem

Starting point: BeReal's daily users fell about 61% from their late-2022 peak. My persona, **Denise**, is an introverted first-time user who feels put on the spot by the 2-minute timer and shut out by the locked feed.

How might we give casual users a second reason to open BeReal, **without** adding pressure or breaking what makes it real?

Guardrails I set before brainstorming. Any idea had to pass all four:

Guardrail	Test
Authentic	Same real, unfiltered photo; no new content requirement
Opt-in	Nothing changes for people who ignore it
Low pressure	No timers, no loss framing, no shame
Friends-only	No public metrics, no strangers

2. Benchmark what drives retention

I studied the features that keep TikTok and BeReal users coming back (full tables), then looked at Snapchat, Instagram and Locket for comparison.

App	Feature	The underlying mechanic
TikTok	For You Page	**Variable reward**: you never know what's next
TikTok	Duets and Stitch	**Participation**: build on what others made

App	Feature	The underlying mechanic
TikTok	Hashtag challenges and streaks	**Shared occasion** plus **progression**
BeReal	Daily random notification	**A daily trigger**
BeReal	Locked feed	**Reciprocity**: give to get
BeReal	RealMoji	**Two-way social response**
Snapchat	Streaks	**Loss aversion**: don't break the chain
Instagram	Candid Stories	**Format copying**: same camera, different trust
Locket	Home-screen widget and Rollcall	**Ambient presence** plus a **weekly recap ritual**

Insight: the features differ, but the mechanics underneath are few: triggers, reciprocity, shared occasions, progression and social response. BeReal already has a trigger and reciprocity. **It's missing a shared occasion and progression.**

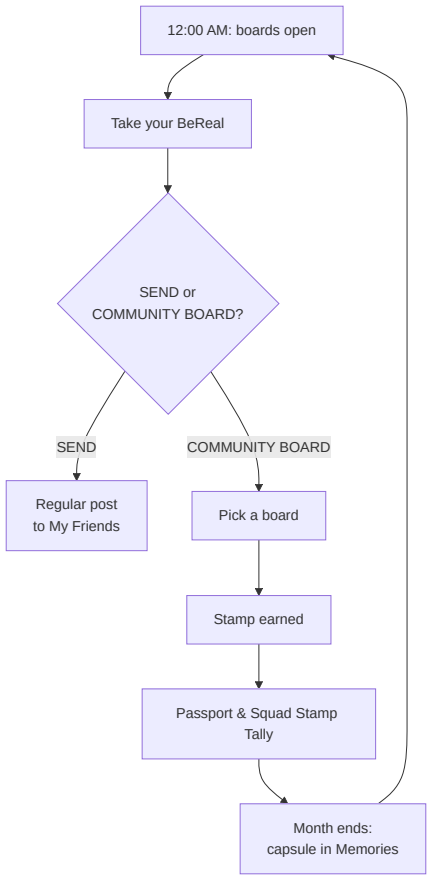
3. Run each mechanic through the guardrails

Mechanic	Authentic	Opt-in	Low pressure	Friends-only	Decision
Variable reward (endless feed)	✅	❌	❌	❌	**Reject**
Participation (remixing)	❌ edits the photo	✅	✅	❌ public	**Reject the remix, keep the idea of participating**
Shared occasion (challenges)	✅	✅	✅ if untimed	✅ if squad-only	**Adapt → monthly themed boards**
Progression (badges)	✅	✅	✅ if no loss	✅	**Adapt → collectible stamps**
Loss aversion (streaks)	✅	❌ feels forced	❌	✅	**Soften → streak cue with nothing to lose**
Reciprocity (locked feed)	✅	✅	⚠️	✅	**Keep**
Social response (reactions)	✅	✅	✅ if private	✅	**Keep → squad-only, no public likes**
Recap ritual	✅	✅	✅	✅	**Adapt → monthly capsule**
Ambient presence (widget)	✅	✅	✅	✅	**Park for later**: good fit, not core to the loop

4. Turn the survivors into features

Mechanic kept	Feature	Prototype detail
Shared occasion	**Community Boards**	October boards: HIKE, CRAMMING, COFFEE and HAUNTED, plus sponsored LITTLE WINS and GAME TIME
Progression	**Real Passport stamps**	One stamp per board post; the October stamp gallery shows earned stamps as Unlocked
Social response	**Squad-only reactions**	Emoji reactions inside the squad, with no public like counts
Recap ritual	**Monthly capsule**	Each month's board saved to Memories as a carousel or collage
Soft trigger	**Reminder hooks**	"3 friends already posted to CRAMMING today" · "You've been real 3 days in a row" · "Come back tomorrow for a new BeReal Passport"
Opt-in	**Settings & Opt-out**	Per-board ON/OFF switches under Settings → Features

5. Design the loop



Key design decision: the photo comes first, the board comes second. Taking a BeReal stays exactly as fast as today; the board choice is a layer on top. Testers later noticed the extra taps this adds, which became the top fix in the Test Plan.

6. Decide what's in the MVP

Priority	Features
Must have	Community Boards; SEND / COMMUNITY BOARD choice; Real Passport stamps; Passport tab; per-board opt-in and opt-out
Should have	Squad Stamp Tally; reminder hooks; monthly capsule
Could have	Sponsored boards and stamps; shorter day- or week-long boards
Won't have (for now)	Comments; public leaderboard; home-screen widget; any streak that can be lost

7. Name the riskiest assumptions

Assumption	If it's wrong	How I'll test it
A shared theme gives casual users a reason to return	No lift in active days	A/B experiment, primary metric (Test Plan)
Stamps motivate without feeling like pressure	Opt-outs rise, or the feature feels "not BeReal"	"Low-pressure" score; board opt-out guardrail
Boards add to regular posting rather than replace it	Regular posts drop	Guardrail: SEND posts must not drop more than 2%
Enough of a squad joins for a board to feel alive	Empty boards, low engagement	Board opt-in rate; empty-state frequency
The extra step after capture is acceptable	Users abandon the flow	Taps and time from shutter to stamped post

8. What testing changed

The 5-person focus group validated the direction: **4 of 5** said they'd open BeReal more often, and reminders scored **4.2/5** for feeling low-pressure. It also showed that the risk wasn't pressure; it was **complexity**. That finding moved the plan from "build the MVP" to "**refine, then retest**" (PRD v2.0).

What I'd tell an interviewer

- I didn't copy features; I copied **mechanics**, and only the ones that passed BeReal's values.
- The most important decisions were **what I rejected**: the endless feed, public likes and loss-framed streaks.
- The feature can be copied, but the brand fit, growing collections and squad rituals around it are much harder to copy (Competitive Analysis).